

PSYC 161: Social Psychology and Individual Differences
Spring 2026, 3:25-4:40pm, Monday/Wednesday

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Office Hours (488 Meliora Hall): Wednesdays, 2:30pm or by appointment

Graduate Teaching Assistants (TAs): see Blackboard
Undergraduate TAs: see Blackboard

Required reading:

1. Packet containing two chapters from Carver, C. S., & Scheier, M. F. *Perspectives in Personality* (6th Edition). Allyn and Bacon: “Types, traits, and interactionism” and “Biological processes and personality” AND one chapter from Brody, N., & Erlichman, H. (Eds.), *Personality Psychology: The Science of Individuality*. Prentice Hall: “Motives and goals”.
Available via bookstore.

2. Packet containing chapters from Myers, D. G. *Social Psychology* (14th Edition). Boston, MA: McGraw-Hill. **Available via bookstore.** I do not recommend the 13th or any earlier edition – there are important changes to each edition.

Organization and aims of the course

This course is designed to provide you with a broad survey of both the field of social psychology and the field of individual differences (personality differences between individuals). The first third of the course will focus on individual differences and their interaction with environmental influences; the second two thirds of the course will focus on specific topics studied in social psychology, including interpersonal attraction, conformity, persuasion/attitude change, and stereotyping/prejudice. The class will be conducted primarily in lecture format, but you will also participate in some small group discussions. In addition, you will complete individual difference questionnaires. At the end of the semester, the questionnaires will be explained, and you will obtain personalized information based on the questionnaires. Lectures will parallel and supplement the material in the required reading. That is, some parts of the lectures will elaborate on material presented in the reading, whereas others will consist of novel material that is not covered in the reading.

**Note on cartoons:* As you will see, I use cartoons in my lectures for illustrative (and, hopefully, humor) purposes. I welcome your own contributions and may use them in the present or a future class, with your permission. If you think you have something relevant, please feel free to pass it my way.

Course requirements, grading, and extra credit

1) Exams. There will be three exams, worth 100 points each. Each exam will cover **only** the material from the preceding section (i.e., all exams are noncumulative). Material from both the lectures and readings will be covered on the exams; some exam material will be from the lectures only, some will be from the readings only, and some will be from both.

Grades will be assigned using a generous (student-friendly) statistically-derived curve based on the overall distribution of scores. For example, I will make sure that approximately 30% of students are in the A range (A, A-), approximately 40% of students are in the B range (B+, B, B-), and approximately 30% of students are below the B range. If students will do better using an absolute grading structure (e.g., A = 100-94, A- = 93-90, B+ = 89-87, etc.) then this will be used instead of the statistically-derived curve.

In accord with general university policy, no makeup exams will be given without a supporting note from UHS. As per university policy, you will be asked to sign the following Honor Pledge on each course exam: “I affirm that I will not give or receive any unauthorized help on this exam, and that all work will be my own.”

2) Questionnaires (see “Questionnaire Schedule” page for dates). You will be asked to complete several questionnaires during the semester. *Completion* of the questionnaires will be graded on a pass/fail basis (if you fail to complete all of the questionnaires, your grade will be lowered by one step, e.g., B to B-). Your *responses* on the questionnaires will not be graded; however, you will receive personalized information based on the questionnaires at the end of the semester. *All information that you provide in the questionnaires will be held strictly confidential!*

3) Essays. For all essays (3 total, each worth 10 points), please write 2 pages using 1-inch margins all around, a Times New Roman 12-point font, and double spacing. Use the full two pages, but no more.

3a) Personal Application Essay. Please write an essay applying some aspect of the individual differences information that we have covered in class to your own personal life. Describe one specific concept discussed in class and/or covered in the readings (in the first paragraph of your essay) and then link it to an experience or event that has occurred in your life (in the remainder of the essay); do so in a thoughtful, precise, and concise way. Your essay will be graded using the following guidelines: turned in on time (2 points), follows the format and length requirements (2 points), clearly and correctly describes the class/reading concept (2 points), clearly describes your experience/event (2 points), and clearly and correctly describes the link between the class/reading concept and experience/event (2 points).

3b) Unplug Day Essay. Please pick a day to unplug from the internet, your phone, and social media contact in general; details will be provided in class. Then, write an essay in which you describe your plan, reason you chose it, and anticipation of how it will go (first paragraph), describe your experience (second paragraph), link your experience to some aspect of Section 2 of the course (third paragraph), and reflect on your practices moving forward – change current practices or not . . . why? (rest of essay).. Your essay will be graded using the following guidelines:..turned in on time and follows format and length requirements (2 points), clearly describes plan, reason, and anticipation (2 points), clearly describes experience (2 points), clearly and insightfully links experience to course (2 points), and clear and thoughtful reflection on change or not (2 points).

3c) Pop Culture Application Essay. Please write an essay in which you identify some aspect of social psychology in pop culture (e.g., a movie, a television show, a song lyric, etc.). Describe one specific concept discussed in class and/or covered in the readings (in the first paragraph of your essay) and then explain how it is addressed or illustrated in the movie, show, song, etc. (in the remainder of the essay); do so in a thoughtful, precise, and concise way. Your essay will be graded using the following guidelines: turned in on time (2 points), follows the format and length requirements (2 points), clearly and correctly describes the class/reading concept (2 points), clearly describes the movie/show/song/etc. (2 points), and clearly and correctly describes the link between the class/reading concept and the movie/show/song/etc. (2 points).

Note on the essay assignments: As per university policy, an Honor Pledge must be written or printed at the bottom of your essay, followed by your signature. The *first sentence* of the pledge should be: “I affirm that I have not given or received any unauthorized help on this assignment, and that this work is my own.” The *second sentence* of the pledge should be one of the following options:

Option 1: “I have not used any form of artificial intelligence (e.g., ChatGPT, Gemini) in writing this essay.” Option 2: “I have used artificial intelligence (e.g., CgatGPT, Gemini), but only in the approved manner.” The approved manner involves two steps. Step 1 is writing and editing your essay on your own until you have a final, unassisted draft; Step 2 is using artificial intelligence to edit the final, unassisted draft. Both versions (with appropriate labels) are to be submitted. The final, assisted version will be the graded version, but the unassisted draft will be consulted and must be of comparable quality. All essays are due at the beginning of class unless stated otherwise.

4) Overall Grade. Your overall grade will be determined on the basis of the three exams (300 possible points), the three essays (30 possible points), and completion of the questionnaires. As with the exams, overall grades will be assigned using a generous (student-friendly) statistically-derived curve based on the overall distribution of scores. For example, I will make sure that approximately 30% of students are in the A range (A, A-), approximately 40% of students are in the B range (B+, B, B-), and approximately 30% of students are below the B range. Again, if students will do better using an absolute grading structure (e.g., A = 100-94, A- = 93-90, B+ = 89-87, etc.) then this will be used instead of the statistically-derived curve.

5) Extra Credit. You may earn up to 8 extra credit points in the course (see “Extra Credit” page for details). If you do the full 8 hours of extra credit, I will *guarantee* that your overall grade will be raised one level (e.g., B to B+), even if your extra credit points by themselves would not do so. If you are under 18 years of age, the UR IRB has different rules for you regarding extra credit – please see me.

Important Notes

**Note on diversity and inclusion:* I encourage all students to ask questions and to voice their perspective in class and in the essay assignments. Disagreement, even about sensitive topics, is encouraged when communicated in a respectful, sensitive manner. Hostile speech or behavior is not acceptable and will not be tolerated. I am committed to fostering an inclusive classroom environment that supports safe, open, trust-based engagement that enables us to learn from each other. My aim for this course is that all students – across gender, ethnicity, race, age, socioeconomic status, sexuality, religion, disability, and cultural background – feel valued, respected, and “heard”. Please do not hesitate to contact me if you have any questions or feedback about any issue related to diversity and inclusion in this class. If I am not accomplishing the aforementioned intentions and aims, I want to know about it and do something about it. If you prefer to communicate to me through a teaching assistant (anonymously or identified), that is perfectly fine.

**Note on academic assistance:* Students needing additional academic assistance are encouraged to contact CETL (the Center for Excellence in Teaching and Learning) in Dewey Hall. I intend to fully support the university’s disability policies: <https://www.rochester.edu/college/disability/>.

**Note on academic honesty:* All assignments and activities associated with this course must be performed in accordance with the University of Rochester Academic Honesty Policies: <https://www.rochester.edu/college/honesty/>.

**Note on religious observance:* I intend to fully support the University of Rochester’s policies on religious observance: <http://www.rochester.edu/College/ccas/handbook/religious-holidays.html>

**Note on credit hours:* This course follows the College credit hour policy for four-credit courses. This course meets twice weekly for a total of 3 academic hours per week, and the course includes independent out-of-class assignments that exceed 1 academic hour per week (e.g., readings, essays, etc.).

Class Schedule and Corresponding Readings

I strongly recommend that you read the material before attending the corresponding lecture.

“Packet 1” = the packet containing the Carver and Scheier chapters and the Brody and Erlichman chapter.

“Packet 2” = the packet containing the Myers chapters.

- 1) 1/21 (W) Introduction
- 2) 1/23 (F) Overview of social psych. and individual differences
- 3) 1/26 (M) Individual differences: Traits and types (Packet 1: “Types, Traits, & Interactionism”)
- 4) 1/28 (W) Continued
- 5) 2/2 (M) Continued
- 6) 2/4 (W) Individual differences: Needs and Motives (Packet 1: “Motives & Goals”)
- 7) 2/9 (M) Continued
- 8) 2/11 (W) Individual differences: Biology (Packet 1: “Biological Processes & Personality”)
- 9) 2/16 (M) Continued ***Essay 1 due***
- 10) 2/18 (W) Interactionism
- 11) 2/23 (M) **Exam 1, 3:25 PM (no time limit on the exam)**

- 12) 2/25 (W) Social cognition and the self Packet 2, Chapters 2, 3
- 13) 3/2 (M) Continued
- 14) 3/4 (W) Continued

- 15) 3/9 (M) No class – spring break Packet 2, Chapters 4, 7
- 16) 3/11 (W) No class – spring break
- 17) 3/16 (M) Attitudes and attitude change

- 18) 3/18 (W) Continued
- 19) 3/23 (M) Continued
- 20) 3/25 (W) Altruism and aggression Packet 2, Chapters 10, 12
- 21) 3/30 (M) Continued ***Essay 2 due***
- 22) 4/1 (W) Continued
- 23) 4/6 (M) **Exam 2, 3:25 PM (no time limit on the exam)**

- 24) 4/8 (W) Stereotyping and prejudice Packet 2, Chapter 9

- 25) 4/13 (M) Continued
- 26) 4/15 (W) Attraction and relationships Packet 2, Chapter 11

- 27) 4/20 (M) Continued
- 28) 4/22 (W) Conformity and group influence Packet 2, Chapters 6, 8

- 29) 4/27 (M) Continued ***Essay 3 due***
- 30) 4/29 (W) Continued and concluding remarks
- 31) TBA) **Exam 3 (Date and time are assigned by the registrar for this day/time slot – it will be during exam week; no time limit on the exam and the exam is NOT cumulative)**

Questionnaire Schedule (tracked on course website)

_____ 1/21 (Wednesday) Information Sheet and Written Release Form
 _____ 1/21 (Wednesday) Questionnaire 1
 _____ 1/24 (Saturday) Questionnaire 2
 _____ 1/28 (Wednesday) Questionnaire 3
 _____ 1/31 (Saturday) Questionnaire 4
 _____ 3/17 Tuesday) Questionnaire 5
 _____ 4/27 (Monday) Questionnaire 6

 _____ 1/26 Extra Credit Questionnaire 1
 _____ 2/21 Extra Credit Questionnaire 2
 _____ 3/19 Extra Credit Questionnaire 3
 _____ 4/14 Extra Credit Questionnaire 4

*Check the course website to make sure that you have received credit for completing the questionnaires; please give the TAs one week to update the website (!). If a week has passed and the website has not been updated, feel free to contact your personal TA to enquire about the delay.

Essay Schedule (tracked on course website)

_____ 2/16 (Monday) **Personal Application Essay due at the beginning of class**
 _____ 3/30 (Monday) **Unplug Day Essay due at the beginning of class**
 _____ 4/27 (Monday) **Pop Culture Application Essay due at the beginning of class**

Exam Schedule (tracked on course website)

_____ 2/23 (Monday, 3:25 PM) **Exam 1**
 _____ 4/6 (Monday, 3:25 PM) **Exam 2**
 _____ **TBA Exam 3 (Date and time are assigned by the registrar for this day/time slot – it will be during exam week; no time limit on the exam and the exam is NOT cumulative)**

Extra Credit

You will have the opportunity to earn extra credit through research participation. Extra credit points will be added to your final score at the end of the class, after initial grades have been established. You can earn up to 8 total extra credit points. There are three primary ways to earn extra credit in the class; you may choose ONE option (most students choose Option 1, but you may choose any of the three options):

Option 1. You will be given 2 extra credit points if you complete the 4 brief (approximately 15-20 minute) extra credit questionnaires (in addition to the 6 that are required for the course) and sign the release forms (see Information Sheet and Written Release Form, both provided separately). In addition, you may earn 6 more extra credit points by signing up for studies offered on SONA (1 extra credit point per hour) and/or writing critical reviews of journal articles. So, to do this option, you

1. Complete the required online questionnaires
2. Complete the online brief extra credit questionnaires (worth 2 extra credit points; tracked on the course website)
3. Complete 6 additional extra credit points on SONA (tracked on SONA) and/via critical reviews.
4. Sign and send the Information Sheet and Written Release Form.

This results in the full 8 extra credit points (2 from the course website, 6 from SONA and/or critical reviews).

Option 2. You may earn all 8 of your extra credit points by signing up for studies that are offered on SONA (1 extra credit point per hour).

Option 3. You may earn all 8 of your extra credit points by reading journal articles and writing critical reviews of them (one extra credit point per 2-page critical review).

Participation in Psychological Research

The Department of Clinical and Social Sciences in Psychology invites students enrolled in this course to participate in research being conducted by faculty, graduate students, and advanced undergraduates. The Department believes that research participation is a valuable opportunity to experience how psychological knowledge is built, and that students can gain insight from participation in research. Students who are 18+ years of age may earn extra course credit by participating as subjects in departmental research and/or by pursuing the alternate route to extra course credit described later in this section. Students who are under 18 years of age may earn extra credit **only** by pursuing the alternate route. Given sufficient availability of studies—which is not guaranteed—participation in research can earn extra credit toward your grade in this course. A total of 8 hours of extra credit is the maximum that may be earned and credited toward a particular course in any given semester, and earning the maximum of eight hours of extra credit is guaranteed to move a student from one passing grade to the next highest grade (e.g., B+ to A-) [this may not apply at the Pass/Fail boundary], but cannot move a student two grade steps (e.g., B- to B+). Credits **are not** retained for later semesters.

Researchers agree to explain fully the general context of the research, its specific purpose, and the study design. Typically, debriefing will occur immediately after participation in the study. If debriefing is delayed, then researchers are required to mail the information to you before the end of the semester. You have a right to understand the research in which you are involved; if you believe a researcher is unwilling to discuss the research with you fully, then you may notify the Director of Undergraduate Studies in Psychology (Christopher Niemiec; niemiec@psych.rochester.edu) or the Chair of the Psychology Department (Loisa Bennetto; loisa.bennetto@rochester.edu).

Researchers commit to following both University and Federal guidelines for obtaining informed consent. The researcher should provide information about what you will be asked to do in the study, any risks or benefits to you, who to contact if you have questions about the study or about your rights as a participant, who will have access to the data you generate—including your identity—and what will happen to your data if you decide not to participate in the study. You are free to withdraw from a study without penalty at any time and receive credit for your time.

Missed appointments (Researcher): Notify the SONA Administrator (exp@psych.rochester.edu) if a researcher fails to keep an appointment. The SONA Administrator will verify your claim and will assign 1/2-hour credit as appropriate.

Important New Policy (Missed Research Appointments by Students)

Missed appointments (Students): Students who acquire more than three unexcused no-shows in the current semester for studies for which they have signed up will lose the opportunity to sign up for further studies in the current semester. In order not to acquire an unexcused no-show for a study for which you are unable to attend, it is necessary that you cancel your sign up via the SONA System at least 24 hours prior to your research appointment. If you are signed up for a study and you do not attend your research appointment, then you will acquire an unexcused no-show for that study. More than three unexcused no-shows will result in your losing the ability to participate in additional research (and receive additional extra credit via this route) in the current semester.

Alternate Route to Extra Credit: If you prefer, or if you are under 18 years of age, then you may pursue an alternate route to earning extra course credit. Your instructor will provide assignments that focus on research in psychology and involve about the same investment of time per point as participating in research. These will involve critical evaluations of research reports (artificial intelligence may not be used in preparing these evaluations). Students may use a combination of approaches to earning extra credit.

Deadline for earning and assigning SONA credits: The SONA System will close at the end of the last day of Reading Period. This means that all participation in SONA research studies must be completed on or prior to this deadline so that experimenters can enter credit into the SONA System. Students must allocate all SONA credits to their psychology courses on or prior to this deadline.

Instructors will retrieve information about SONA credits on, and only on, the day after the SONA System closes.

SONA Procedures

- Be 18 years of age or older
 - If you are under 18 years of age, then you may earn extra course credit by the alternate route described above
- Log on to the SONA website at <http://urochester.sona-systems.com/>
 - Use your eight-digit **Student Number** as both your SONA User ID and your Password
 - If you cannot log on, then it means that the SONA System does not have a record of you
 - Enrollment data are typically uploaded to the SONA System in the second week of the semester. You will receive an e-mail notification that the SONA System has been activated for the term
 - If the SONA System is active and you cannot log on, then contact the SONA Administrator (expHELP@psych.rochester.edu) and provide the following information:
 - Your name
 - Your eight-digit Student Number
 - Your UR e-mail address
 - Your CSP or PSY courses for this semester
 - Give department and number (e.g., PSY 101)
 - The SONA Administrator will enter you into the SONA System and have an e-mail message sent to confirm your User ID and Password
- Once logged on to the SONA website, you can:
 - See what studies and appointments are available
 - Sign up for studies
 - See your appointments
 - See the credit you have been assigned by researchers
 - Assign your credit to specified courses as you decide (if you are in more than one course that accepts SONA credit)
- The SONA System will close at the end of the last day of Reading Period
 - No appointments should be scheduled after this date
 - This is the last day you can assign SONA credits to your courses
- **IMPORTANT:**
 - **Participation in research is voluntary; it is not required**
 - **You must allocate your credits to your courses if you are in more than one course that accepts SONA credit**
 - **SONA credits earned this term must be used during this term**
 - **Send any questions or concerns to expHELP@psych.rochester.edu**